

■ By Sharda Ugra

As the Indian Premier League (IPL) was counting down to opening night, a certain sponsor had a bright idea. Instead of umpires opening matches by calling out the mundane word, "Play", why didn't they bellow, "Let the good times begin?" The idea was dismissed, too far-out even for a league in which the umpires had swapped white coats for red shirts and Stetsons. But as India's new-age cricketing carnival reached its climax, everyone caught in its undertow—players, spectators, owners, sponsors—could testify that it had really been a heady, hedonistic, all-round good time.

In the eyes of those who conceived of it and set it in motion—BCCI vice-president Lalit Modi and Co.—the IPL is an event that will radically alter the shape of the game and leverage more power their way. To those who invested in it, it has been brand-builder and attention-grabber that shook up the television business and will redraw the contours of the global cricket economy. To millions of Indians, it was a six-week fix of their favourite sport, cricket on speed and at high volume, packaged and sold as prime-time entertainment.

It had kicked off at Bangalore's Chinnaswamy Stadium before a capacity crowd that could not decide who to watch or what to cheer. Six weeks later, on the finals night, spectators were clued in, switched on and had taken sides. The cheer leaders barely registered on anyone's radar; the movie-stars came, danced and departed. Cricket and its shortest, fastest and most breathless version played by the best drawn from all over the world had become the centre-piece again.

From start to finish, the demand for the IPL never dipped either on television or on ground across the country. Watched by 99 million people out of an estimated total television audience of 131 million, average TV ratings for the first 44 games stood at 4.71, regardless of the below-par production qualities. The BCCI would pocket close to Rs 350 crore and the overall size of the cricket economy would, according to IPL CEO Sundar Raman, grow by over 50 per cent, from Rs 3,200 crore to Rs 4,800 crore.

If not anything else, the IPL always surprised. Shoaib Akhtar picked up Virender Sehwag's wicket and heard the Eden Gardens explode with joy. Kiwi Stephen Fleming was suddenly late-night pillion rider on the back of M.S. Dhoni's high-speed bike on the East Coast road out of Chennai; Mohammed Kaif, knocked out cold after a crunching collision with Kamran Akmal, was given a CT scan and eight stitches in the middle of the final before he headed out to bat. To Preity Zinta, every match day was, she says, an exercise in "instant

karma"; Chennai Super King's Director of Cricket Operations V.B. Chandrasekhar wondered about his, after emails to Makhaya Ntini, his final, gut-feel auction pick, kept bouncing back; Kings XI CEO Neil Maxwell's IPL 'office' was a coffee table and three sofas in a fifth-floor lounge at the Taj Chandigarh and the tournament's parties often ended with players heading for the breakfast buffet before going to bed.

In this unfettered love-fest between cricket, entertainment, business and media, the two teams with the strongest backgrounds in the sport got to the final. India Cements, who won the Chennai Super Kings, have spent decades in Tamil Nadu



FUN TIME: Ecstatic crowds at a match (above); Rajasthan Royals with the first DLF-IPL trophy

cricket. Emerging Media, owners of the Rajasthan Royals, had what CEO Fraser Castellino called, "relevant experience" as commercial partners of Leicestershire County Cricket Club. Their home work and research brought together a low-profile, high-impact team led by a charismatic captain.

When Sneha Rajani, executive vice president of rights holders SET Max, called IPL "TV's ultimate reality show," she was not trying to be allegorical. She was being dead serious.

But at the end, the Royals proved that the show and the business were merely handy props and nice packaging. What made the IPL work was at its core, immune to big bucks or star power. What made everything—the Royals, the Super Kings, the television ratings, the IPL itself—work was cricket.

99
million people
or 76% of
the total
trackable TV
audience of
131 million
watched
the IPL over
six weeks.

Total number
of players in
the IPL

163.

There were 96
Indians and 67
foreigners.

Rs 9,000

crore is the
worth of the
IPL including
teams and
sponsors.

Rs 4,800

crore is the
size of the
cricket
economy. A
rise of 50%
post-IPL.

Rs 4.8

crore was the
winner's prize
money at the
inaugural IPL.